

Pictures by A PRABHAKAR RAO



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state's economic adviser D.A. Somayajulu. "The economy is robust as revenues leapt from Rs 25,000 crore three years ago to Rs 70,000 crore and we have surpassed states like Maharashtra and Gujarat," he adds.

Reddy is determined to capitalise on these highs. His initials YSR are eponymous for the endearing respect and unflinching loyalty he commands among staunch supporters, not just in the Congress rank and file but also in the state's bureaucracy. And to strike an emotive chord, Reddy made sure that at least one, if not two, of the major welfare measures reached and benefited every family in the state.

Few chief ministers in command of a large state can claim to have travelled as extensively as he did. Not only did he visit all 22 districts—between 30 and 35 times in five years—for an enduring rural connect, but he also followed it up with an aggressive one-man show—the final campaign tour through 170 of the 294 constituencies in just 29 days. It is this that has led to an impressive performance, winning 33 of the 42 Lok Sabha constituencies and 156 of the 294 assembly seats with 73 first-time contestants.

A wily strategist, he revved up the Congress party machine in a manner that legislators became accountable for popular support in their constituencies. Based on a detailed constituency and contestant analysis, he could drop sitting legislators without a murmur of protest and field what he jocularly calls "winning horses".

Reddy's commitment in reaching out to voters is indeed indefatigable. Evidently, relying on the fundamentals of his medical college education, he has drawn up a prescription to address the needs of all sections of society and cure the state's ills. But it will take a year to see how his magic potion really begins to work. ■

30 million

of the 80 million people in the state is the reach of the top class mobile and ambulance healthcare services.



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menting welfare measures like the Abhaya Hastham, old-age pension schemes, Indiramma housing and other Reddy initiatives. On his part, the chief minister is working on a twin strategy. He is contemplating the creation of the office of commissioner of social security for effective implementation of all schemes and is also carefully setting up targets to make sure that every single deserving person avails the benefits. This will help check grain drain and bogus claims from different welfare programmes, avoid wastage of resources and improve their financial management.

The more critical element of the twin strategy is to find the mind-boggling sums for taking up and completing the majority of the projects under Jalayagnam. Reddy will be looking up to the Central Government to fund some of the larger irrigation projects, like Polavaram, Pranahita-Chevella and Uttara Andhra Sujala Sravanthi which will water large tracts that are bigger in size than some of the smaller states, as national initiatives.

Can Andhra Pradesh do it? "It is possible that higher public investments will also encourage the flow of greater private investments," says the